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Offering Content Reporting

A dashboard for service offering teams that provides visibility into their offering's readiness and consultant usage.

GOAL

The dashboard aimed to help service offering teams manage the lifecycle of their Offering and integrate them into a new content management system, Content+.

CLIENT AND SCOPE

The internal client for this project was a cross-functional team representing IBM Services and lasted 4 months in 2020.

ROLE

I owned the reporting dashboard and my biggest contribution was building out its interface.

OUTCOMES

I delivered a high-fidelity prototype that articulated a new governance model and provided qualitative feedback for the first time.

How might we design a better way for offering team members to maintain quality offering content?

IBM Services sought to reinvent the client experience and faced ingrained set backs
In 2019, IBM Services renewed their focus on changing its perception. Rather than acting as “tech plumbers,” they needed to show up as strategic partners to reinvent how clients get business done. Yet while IBM Services expected consultants to be strategic partners, the world they had built around them empowered them as solution sellers. Consequently, IBM Services faced challenges ingrained in its culture, processes, incentives, messaging, and tooling.

My design organization targeted the tools consultants use and formed Content+
Our executive sponsor targeted the tools consultants use to perform work and chartered my design organization to unravel the possibilities. After investigating the problem, they brought together a cross-functional team to put consultant content under one roof and empower it with modern user experience standards. The platform would be called Content+.

My role focused on reporting for offering teams to serve consultants
As a new phase of the project began, I joined the Content+ team to build on Quarter in Review report I designed for offering leaders. Content+ foremost served consultants, but offering teams were critical members of the ecosystem because they provided content.

Consultants lacked fresh and calibrated content to use for client opportunities
Consultants needed better content because they wasted time synthesizing the disparate, disjointed capabilities and materials into a client’s context. A glaring driver contributing to this issue was the poorly maintained content provided by offering teams.

Content was often outdated, not reflecting current market conditions or corporate strategy. Other times teams hosted an old version on one platform and a new version on a different platform. Second, the content tended to be either too technical or simplistic. Audiences close to an offering’s practice could fill these gaps, but the broader consultant audience struggled to translate how capabilities provided value to a client’s business.

Offering teams lacked the incentives and feedback to make improvements
IBM Services weakly incentivized offering teams to manage their offering content and governing groups had limited influence. However, Content+ would bring together the right stakeholders to provide greater accountability.

Offering teams lacked centralized and sufficient data for decision support
A medley of platforms hosted usage metrics. Gaining a complete picture of Offering content usage and performance meant piecing together a patchwork of data stored across several sources. Even if brought together, teams received only rudimentary metrics, such as views and downloads. Data they might use to measure the effectiveness of their content was entirely missing.

My vision extended how teams manage the lifecycle of their offering
I focused on two areas that would target improving the quality of offering content for consultants and clients. First, I sought to define how to surface Content+’s governance model to teams. Second, I sought to aid offering teams performing life cycle activities they were already doing:

- Tracking internal campaigns to promote offering.
- Strategizing internal campaigns, like selecting a channel or gaining understanding of their user base.
- Evolving their offering content and soliciting feedback.

Offering Content Dashboard user flow

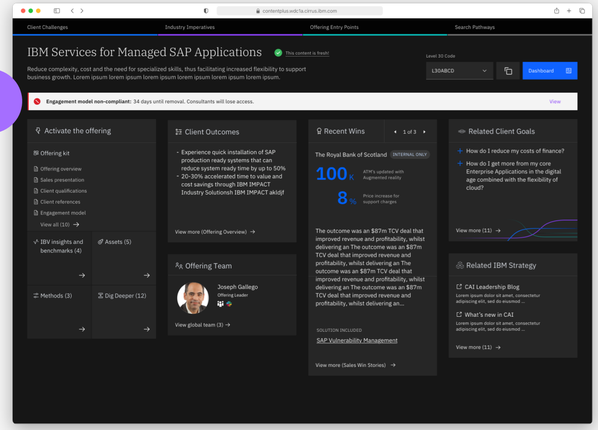
When offering content is low performing, high performing, or risks removal for non-compliance, offering team members receive an alert. One way the experience alerts teams is in their offering's profile within Content+ (A).

Alerts link them directly to a view of the specific offering content, or artifact (B). In this case, it is the offering's engagement model. Teams then receive guidance to resolve the alert and information on how the artifact is performing.

Offering team members don't need alerts to access the dashboard. From the Offering Profile they can tab over to the Offering Dashboard (C), taking them to a summary view of offering content performance.

Additionally, team members responsible for marketing and enabling the offering can view the Offering Profile dashboard view to receive information on ecosystem and user activity (D).

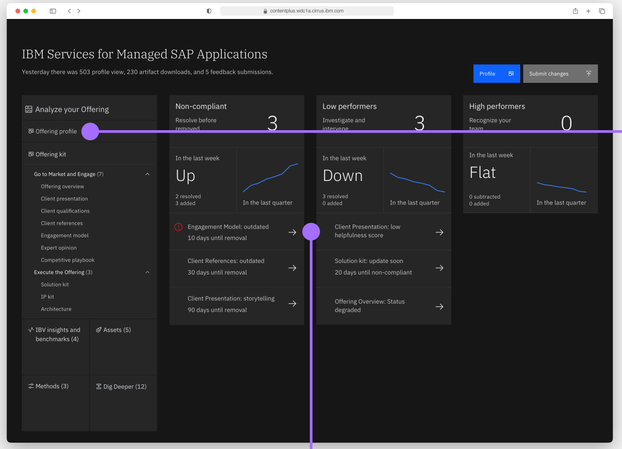
Offering Profile view



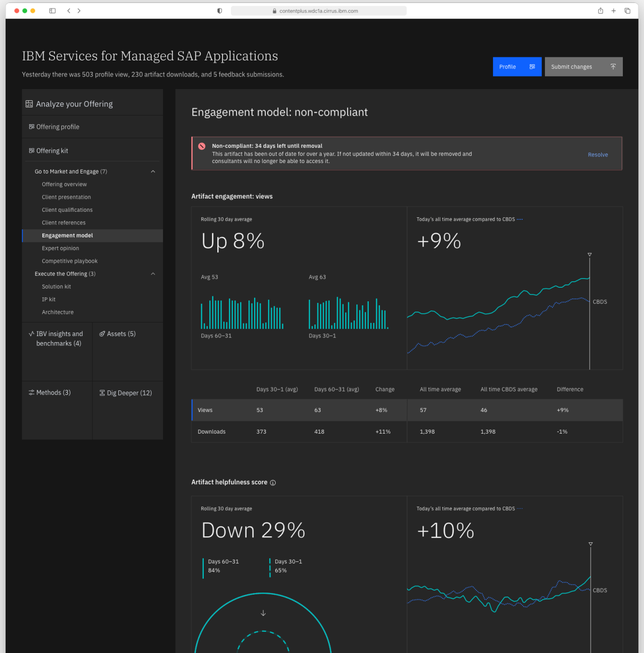
A

C

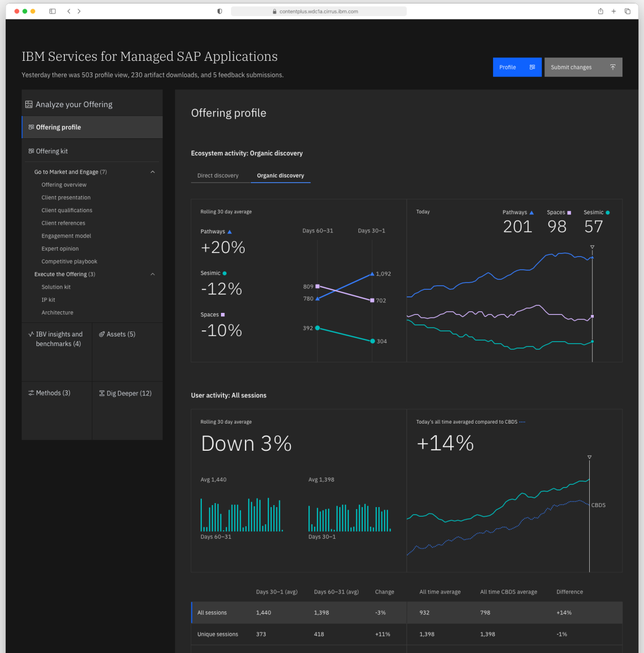
Offering dashboard view



B Artifact dashboard view



D Offering Profile dashboard view



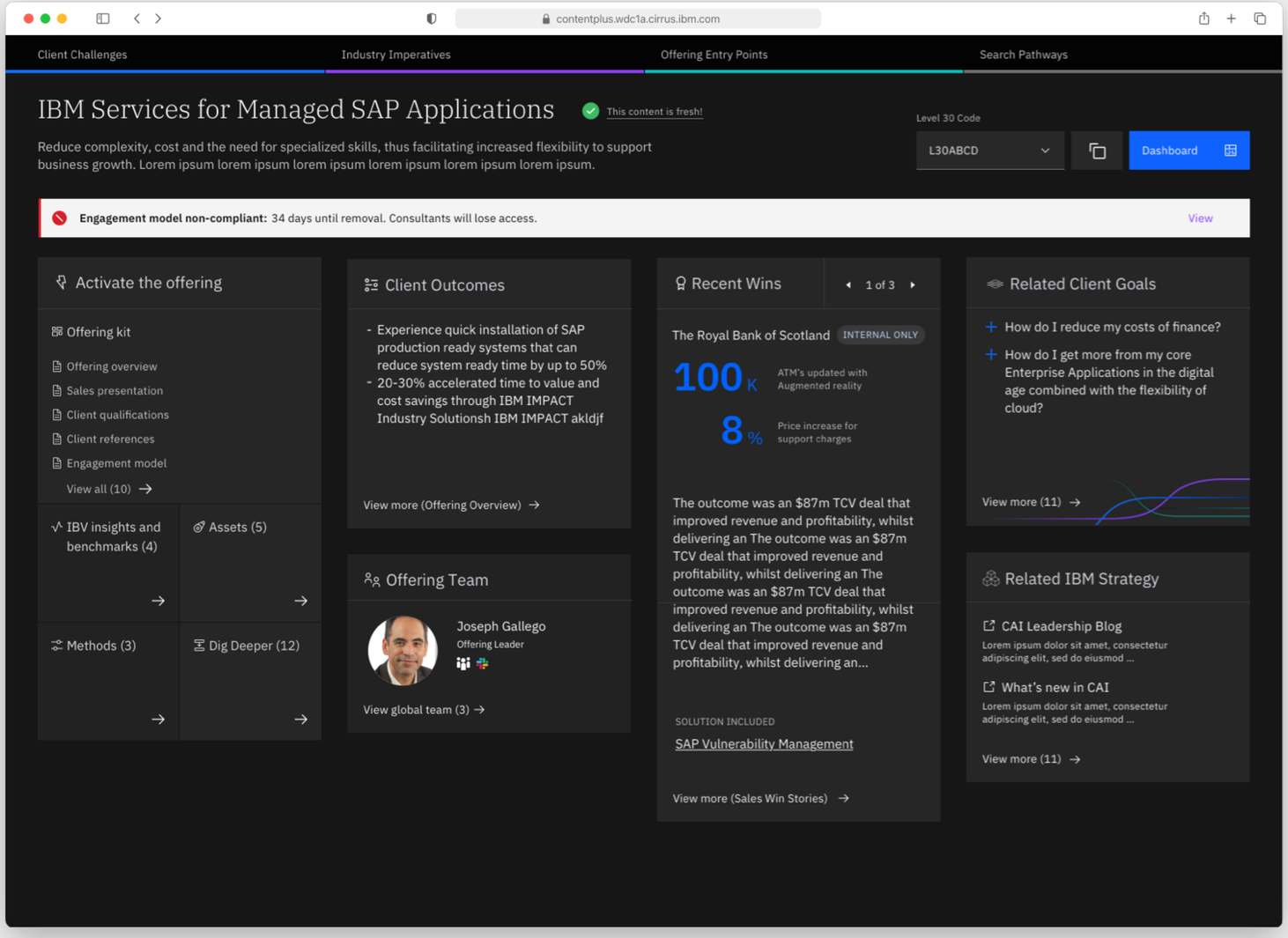
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Offering Profile view



Offering Content Dashboard user flow

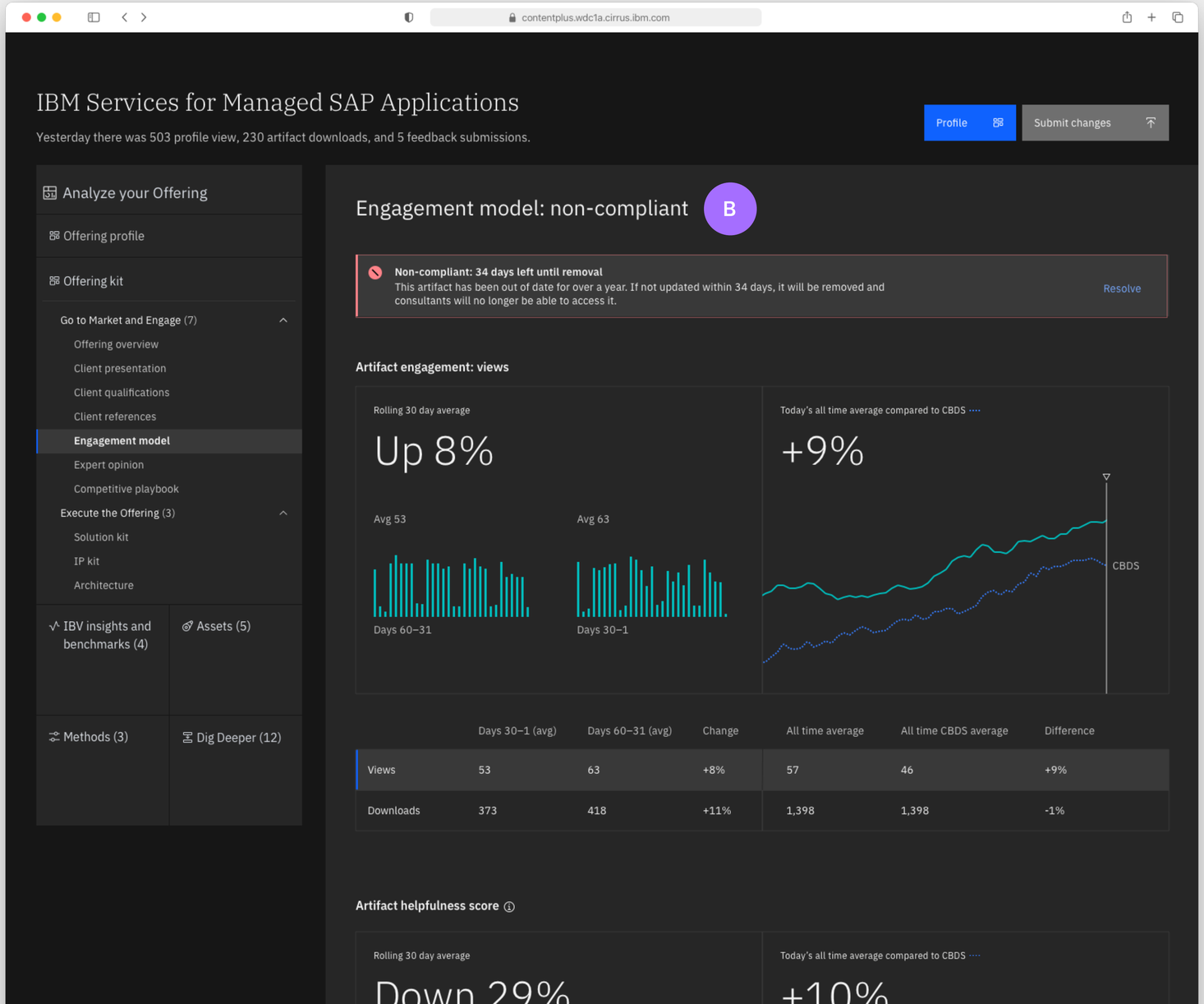
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Artifact dashboard view



Offering Content Dashboard user flow

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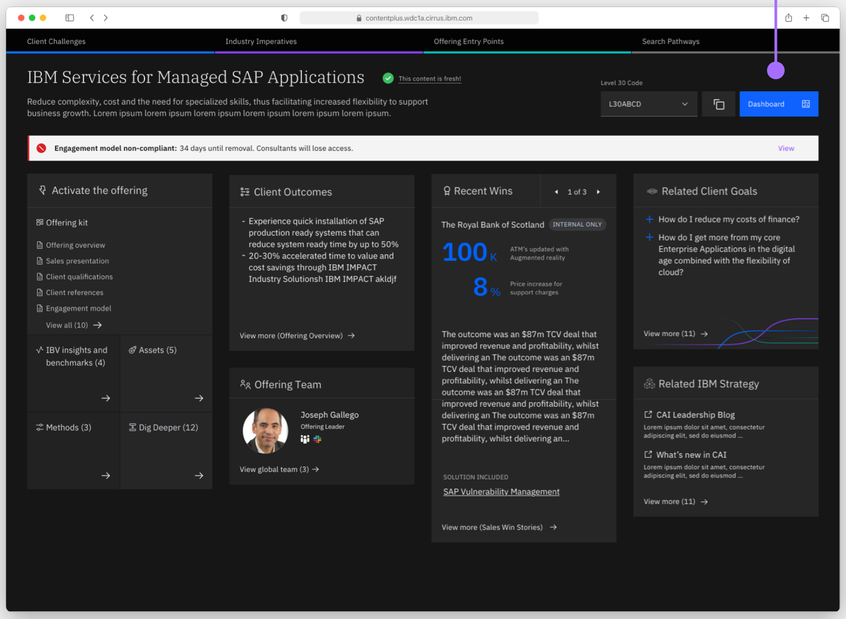
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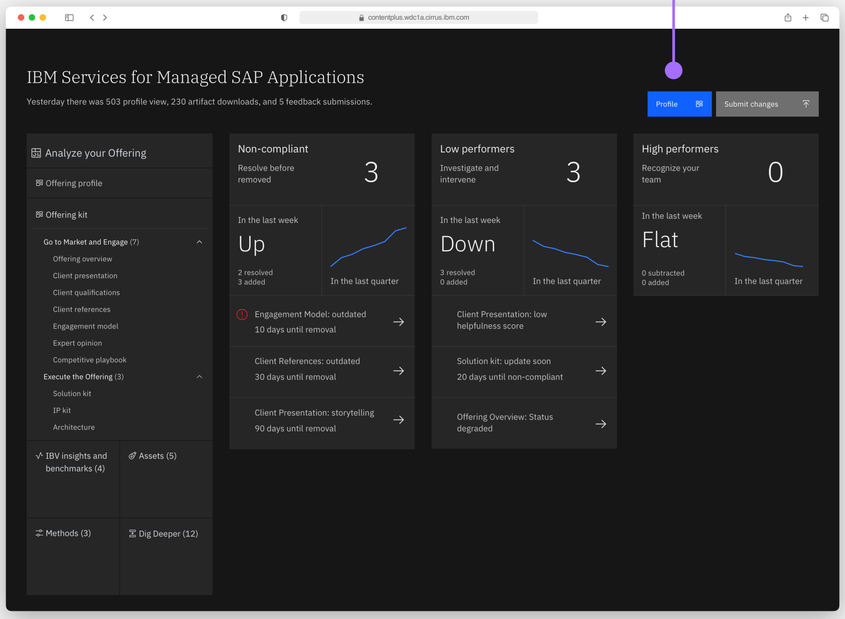
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C

Offering Profile view



Offering dashboard view



Offering Content Dashboard user flow

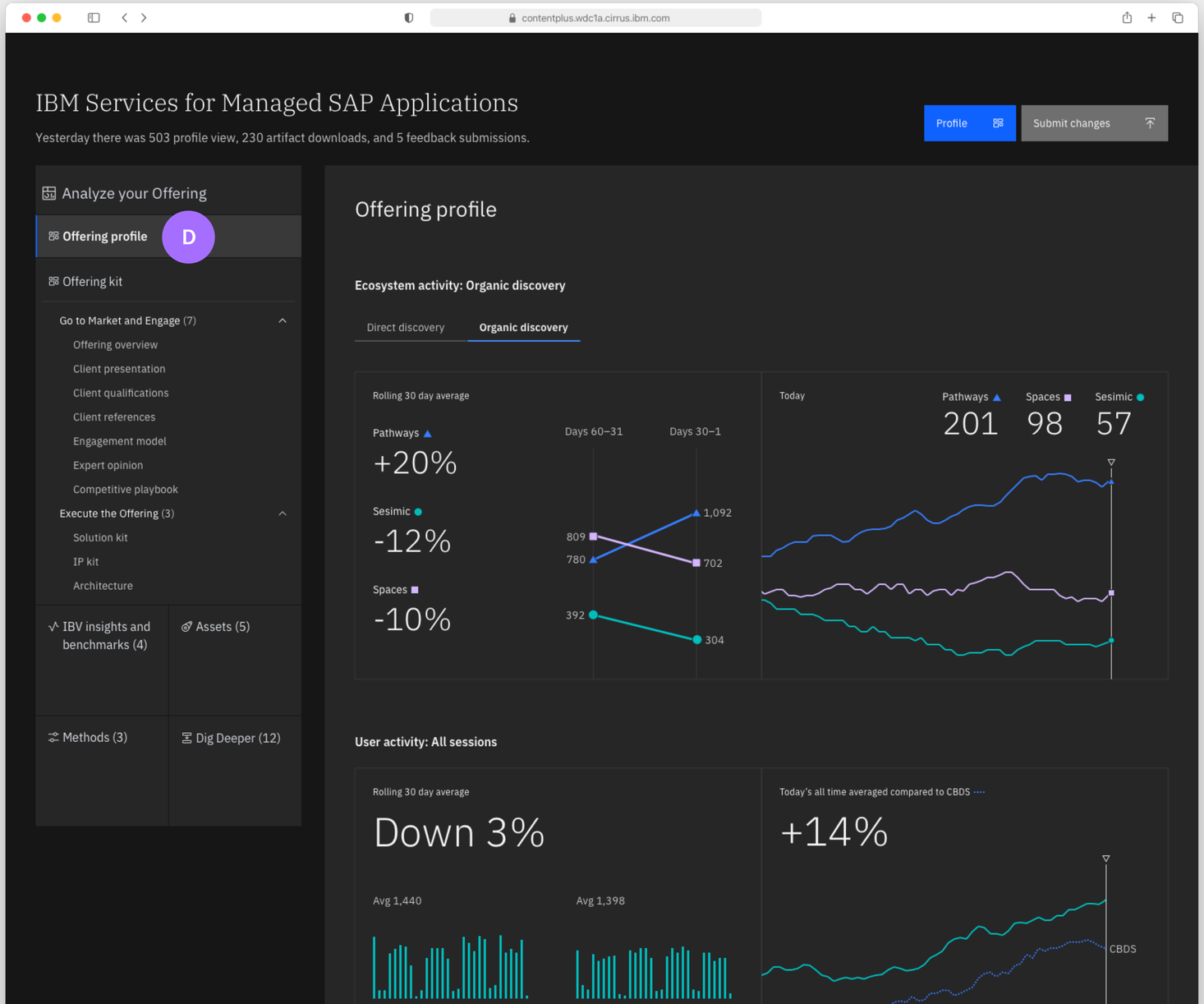
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Offering Profile dashboard view



Offering Content Dashboard user flow

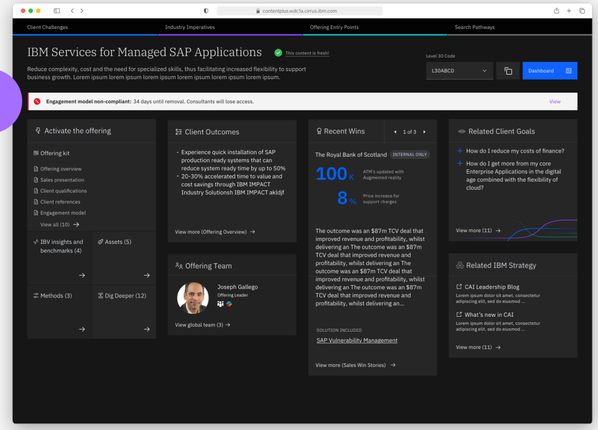
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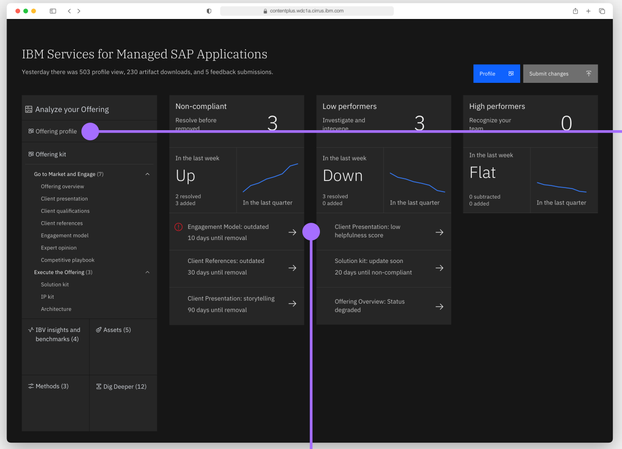
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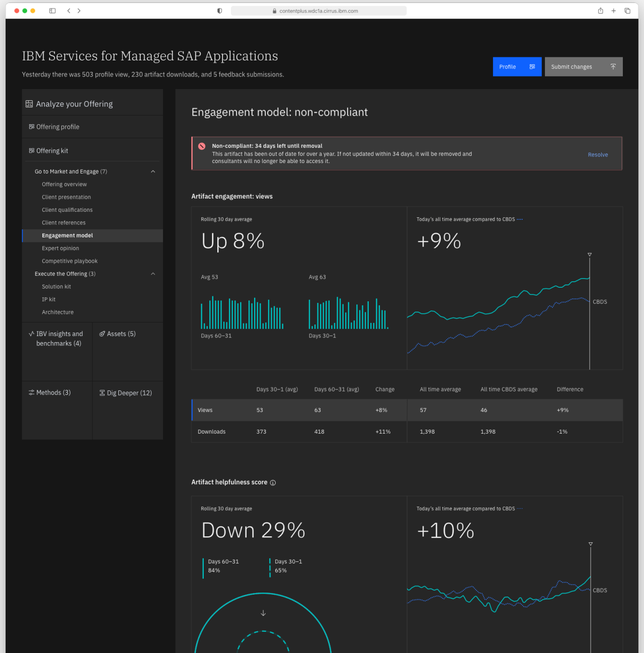
A

C

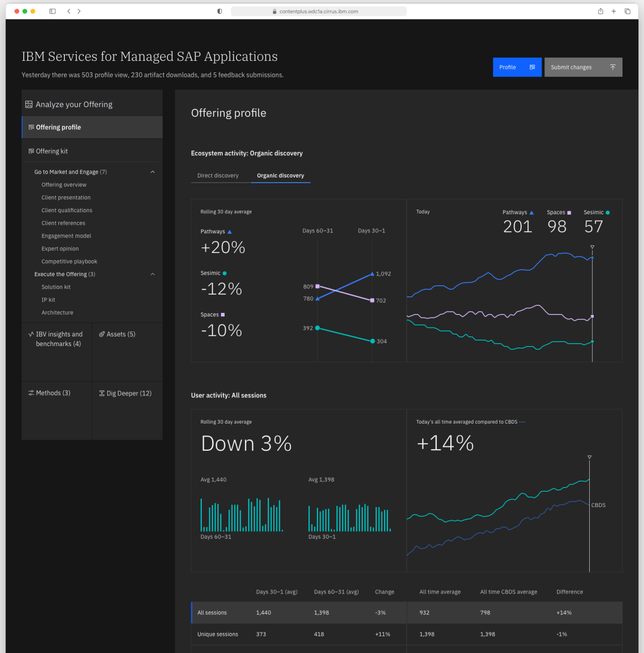
Offering dashboard view



B Artifact dashboard view



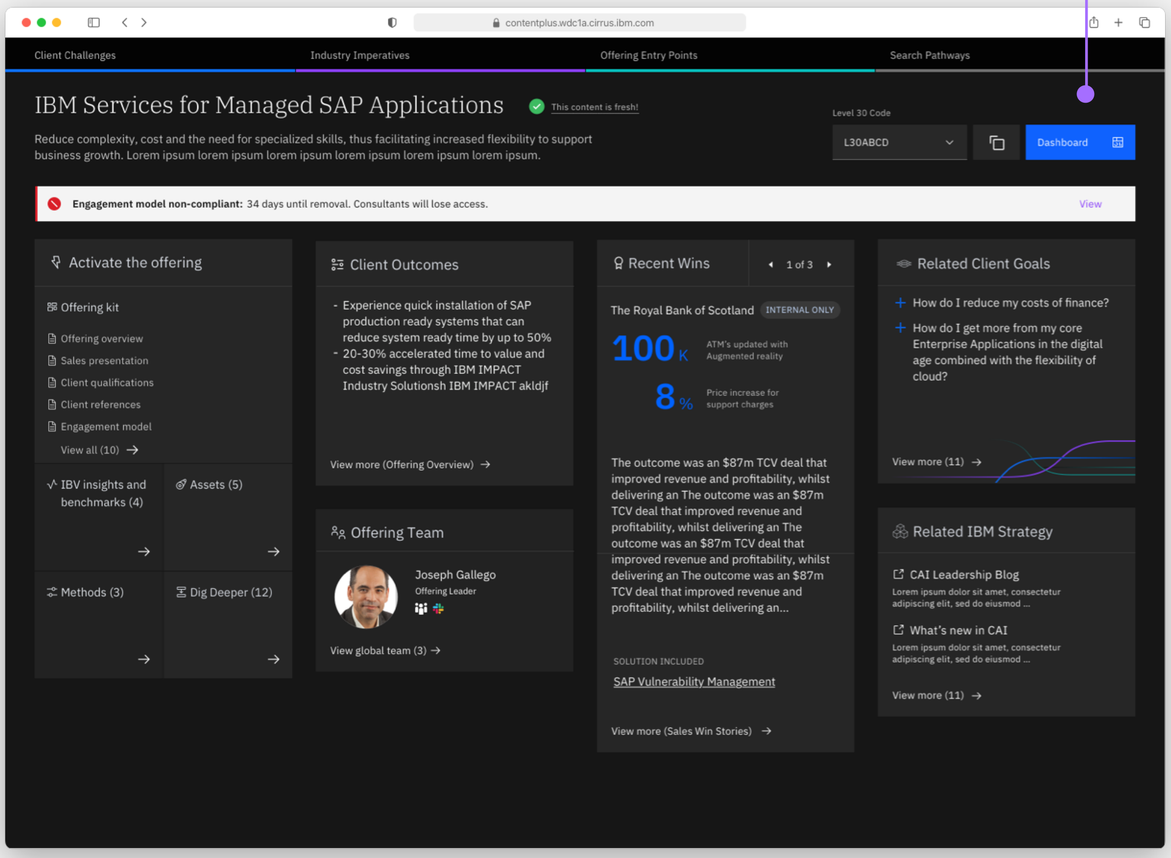
D Offering Profile dashboard view



Design Decision

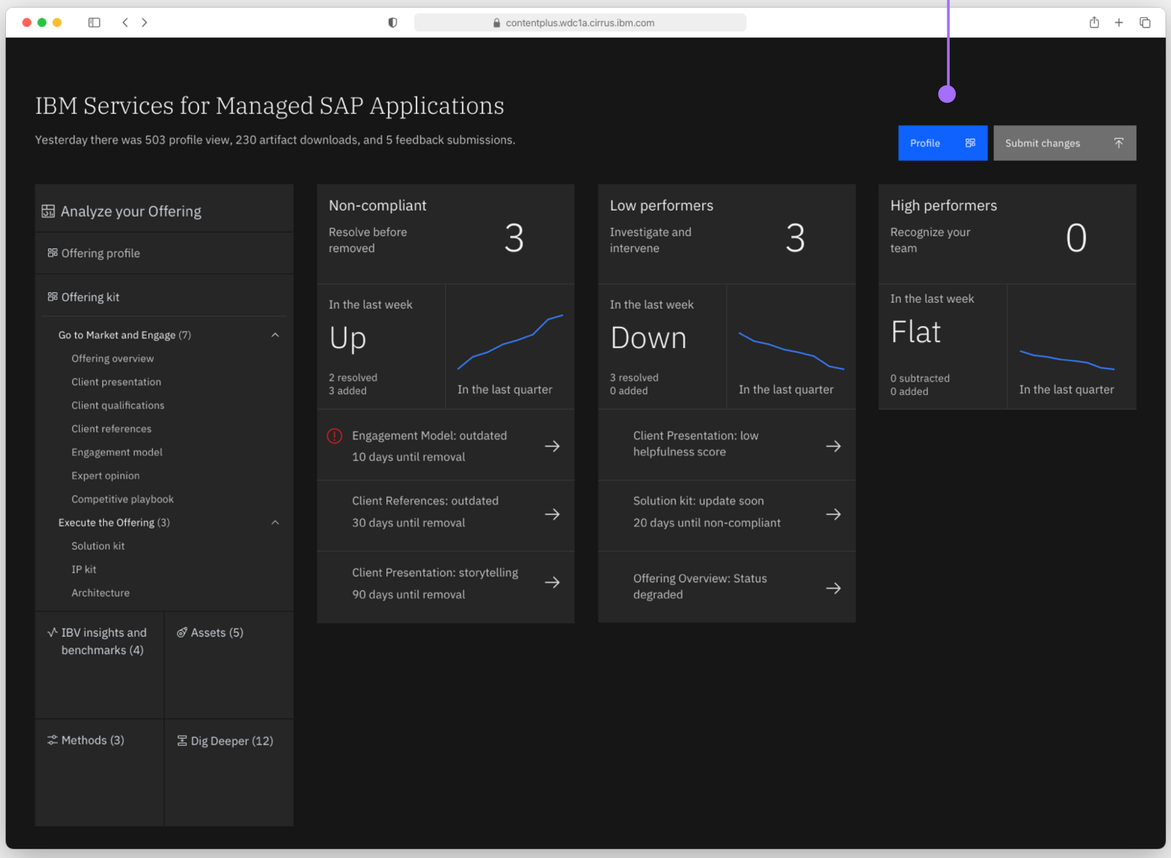
I made the decision to integrate reporting with the Content+ experience to drive adoption of the dashboard and reduce mental models.

A



Offering Profile overview

Offering team members switch to the dashboard from the Offering Profile (A).



Offering Dashboard overview

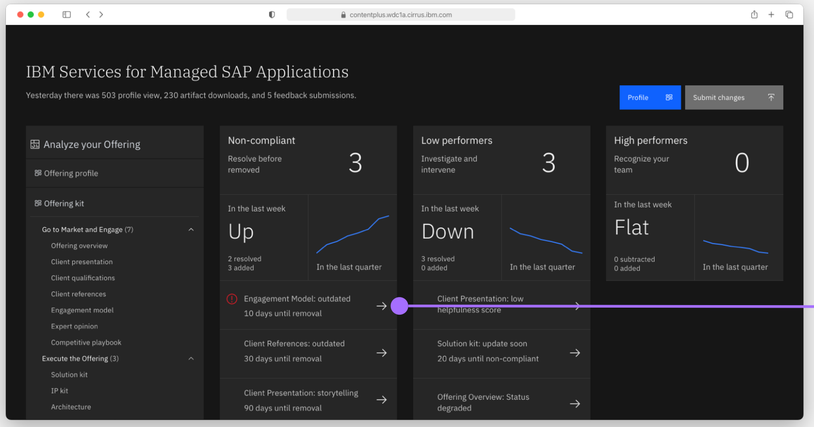
The Offering Profile and Dashboard share layout and navigation patterns.

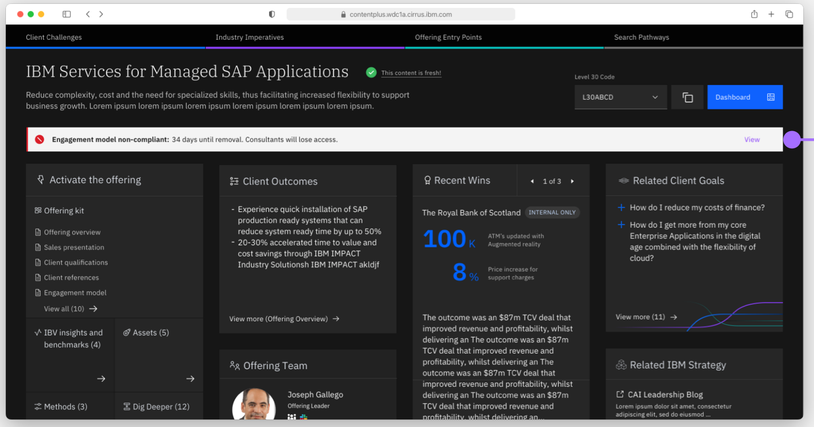
Design Decision

To drive adoption of healthy offering management behavior, I used the reporting experience to communicate rules set by governance in addition to persuasive design patterns that stir up intrinsic motivators.

Alerts (A)

Alerts drive Offering team members toward urgent actions that need resolution.

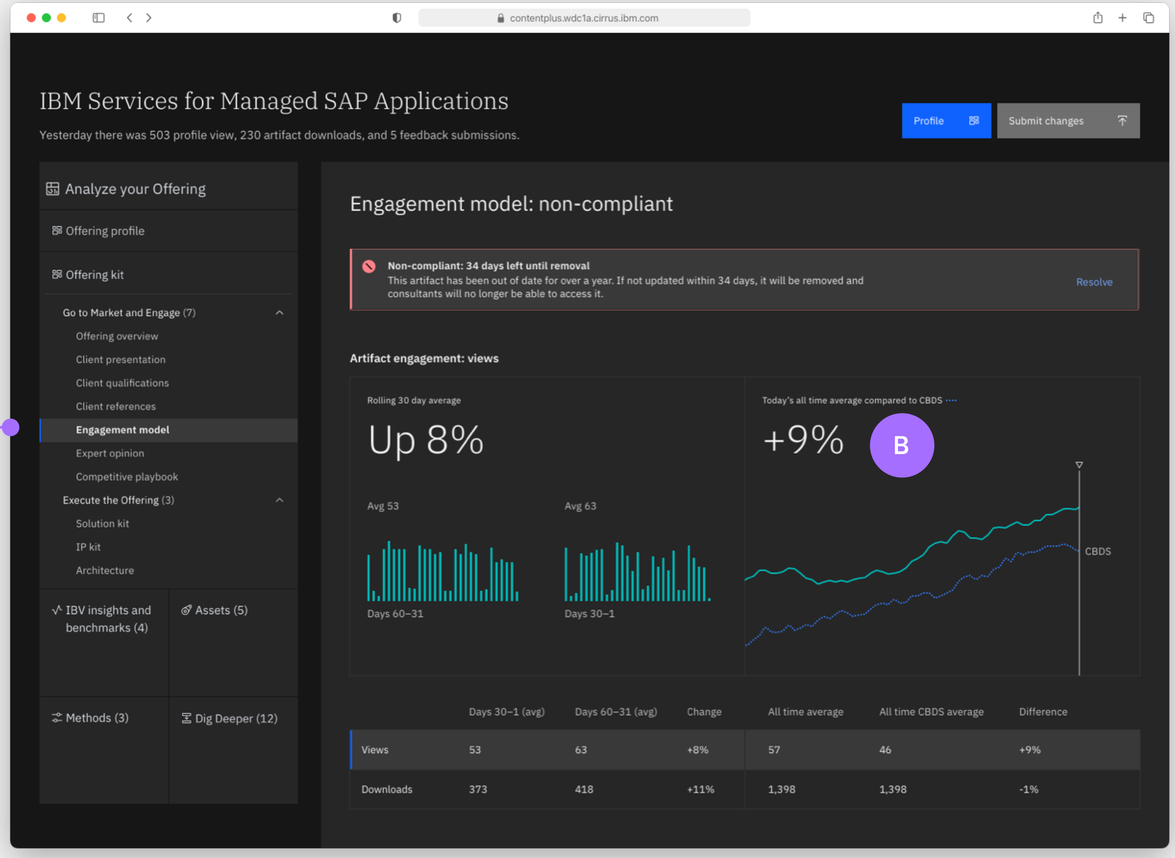




A

Benchmarking (B)

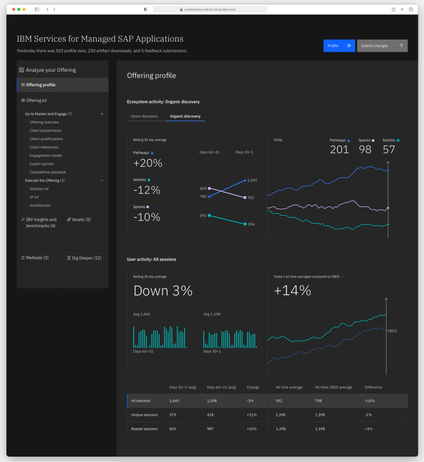
Offering teams will be motivated to be similar to or compete with their peers.



Design Decision

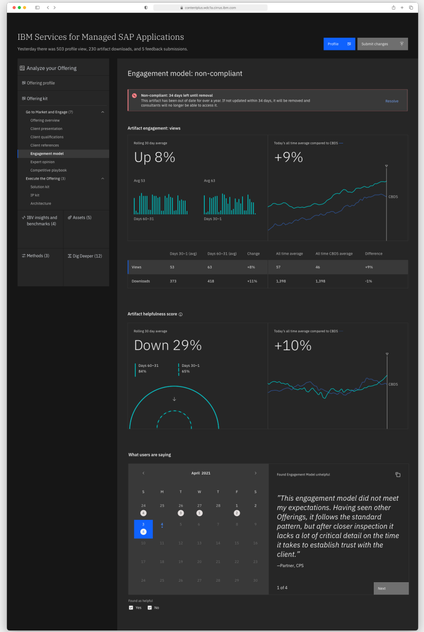
To be efficient with an Offering team's focus, I prioritized showing conclusions first then providing evidence second using various visual design principles.

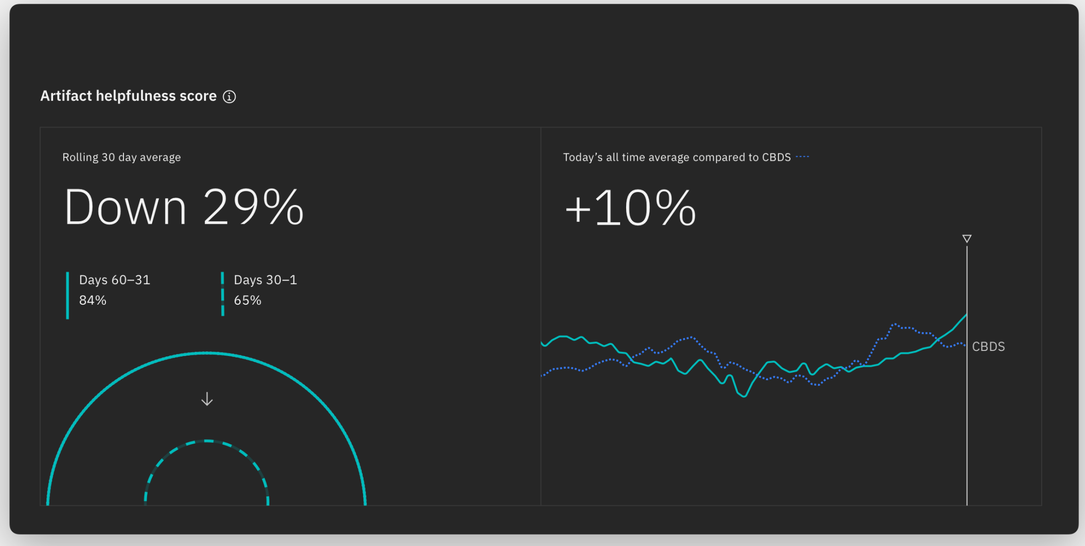
Offering profile view





Artifact detail view

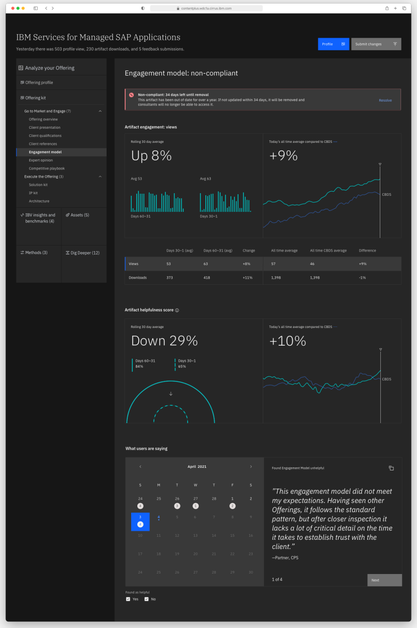


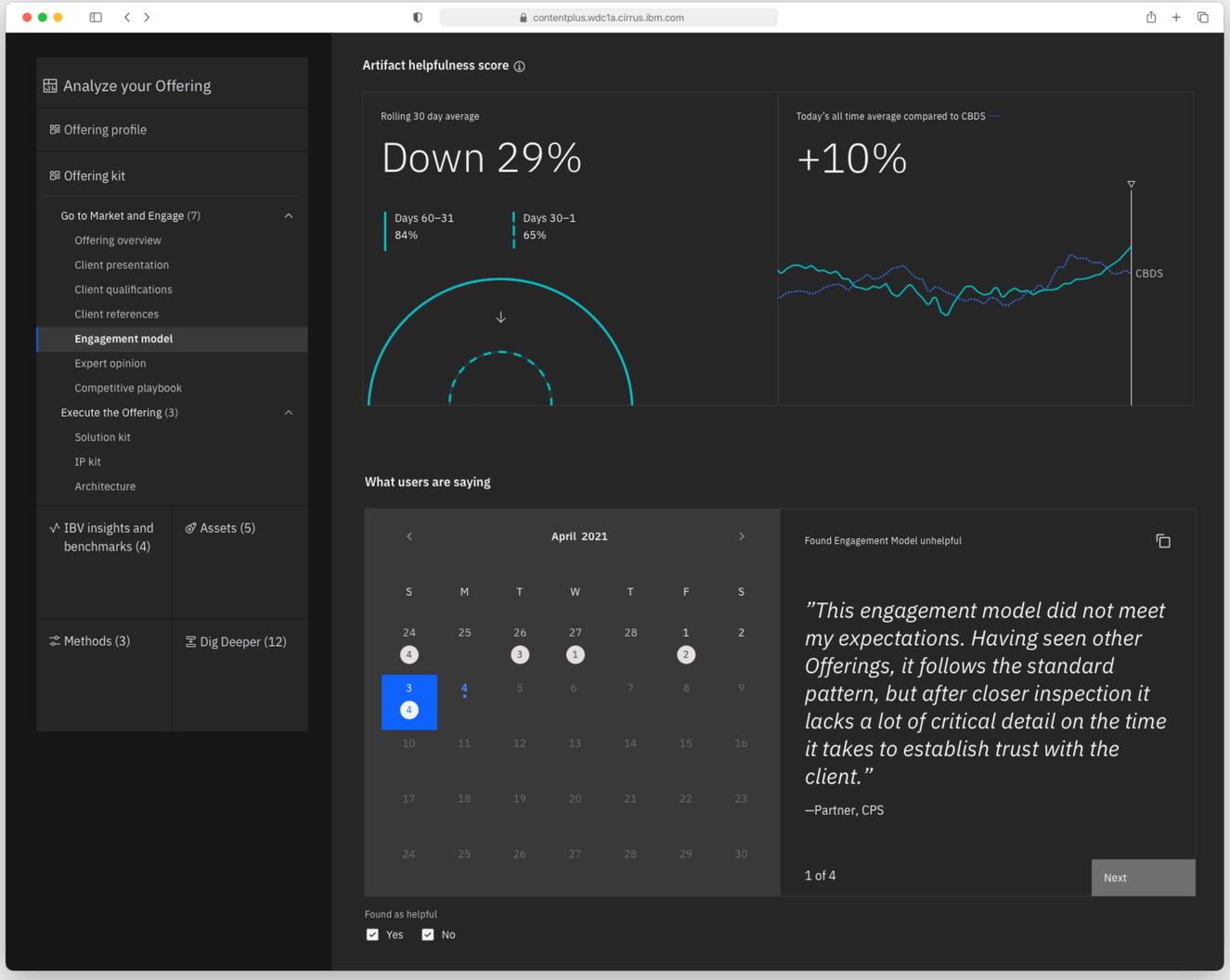


Design Decision

To provide deeper insight that guides offering lifecycle activities, I used rich usage data, qualitative feedback, and offered it in real time.

Artifact detail view





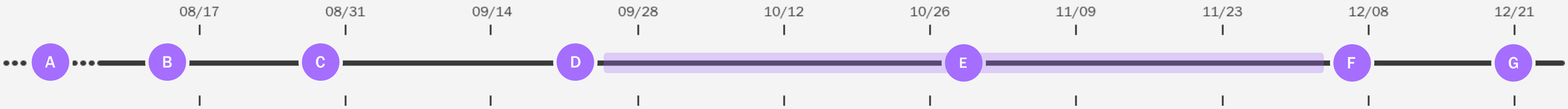
Helpfulness score

Offering teams can understand how an artifact's helpfulness is trending.

Quotes

Sorely missing, Offering teams can start to understand the underlying reasons for their content's performance.

Content+ dashboard timeline
4 months, Q3–Q4 2020



(A) Integrated Experience team forms
The team identified the conditions for adoption, performed user research, and high-level ideation.

(B) Content+ kicks off
I join the team to support Content+ and start by co-designing a minimal adoptable experience for content migration.

(C) Framing and research playback
This playback centered on migration, but its findings also informed the offering team's reporting needs.

(D) Work on reporting experiences begins
I began several interrelated work streams to support quality content on Content+, including a reporting experience.

(E) Prototyping, testing, and alignment
I created a range of prototypes to narrow in which experiences and data sources the new platform could support.

(F) Report approach playback
I presented a high-fidelity prototype and pivoted to designing a dashboard supporting real-time data and alerts.

(G) Dashboard approach playback
I presented a high-fidelity prototype. As Content+ shifted from a project to a program, I exited the team.

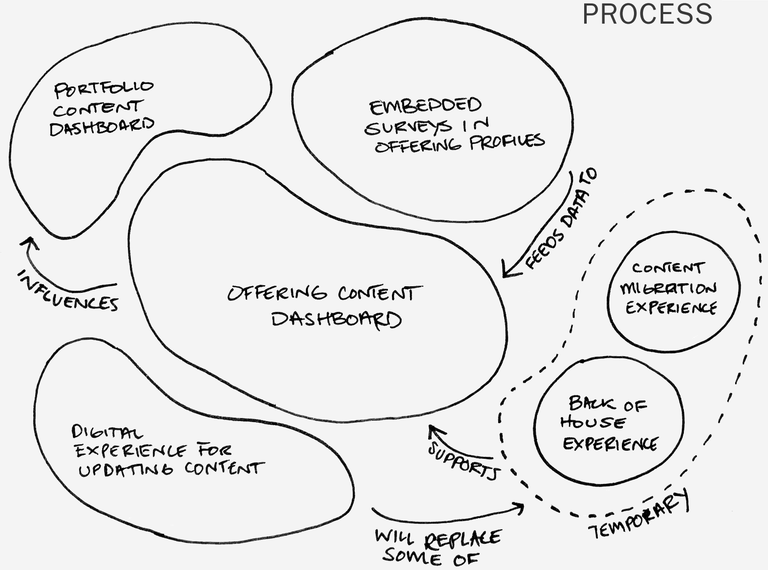
Research about how teams updated content applied to reporting and more

While our design organization had some understanding of offering teams, how an offering team worked together to update content was lesser known to us.

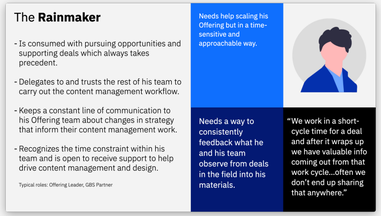
To fill this gap, I led two rounds of research, the development of personas (A), and a set of recommendations for a playback. The research made visible who on the team updated content and what motivated the updates.

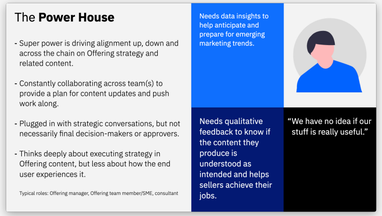
The research had applications beyond a reporting experience. I also spent my time working on an ecosystem of experiences that supported our goal of ensuring updated and relevant for content for consultants (B).

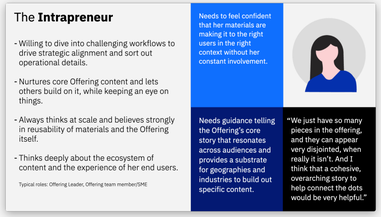
B

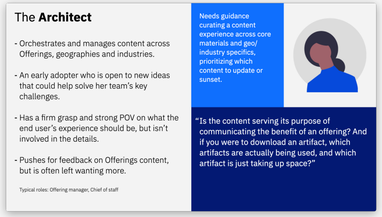


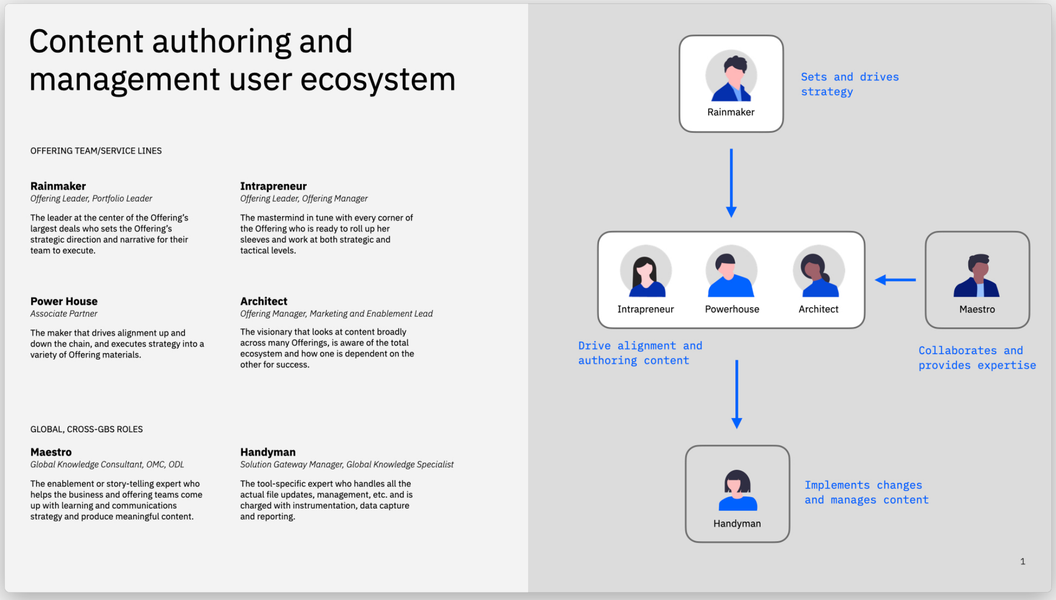
A











I managed uncertainly with diverse collaboration and an adoption mindset

Content+ would sit on a new content management system, Adobe Experience Manager (AEM), and we expected it to offer new usage data, real-time availability, and more.

Exactly when we could benefit from its capabilities and data was a constant moving target throughout the project. To manage the uncertainty, I co-led a workshop with our partnered teams to gain more clarity (A).

Then, I combined my understanding of the technical constraints with how I expected offering teams to behave.I weighed my ideas with adoption because of how difficult it was to motivate our users to maintain their offerings (B).

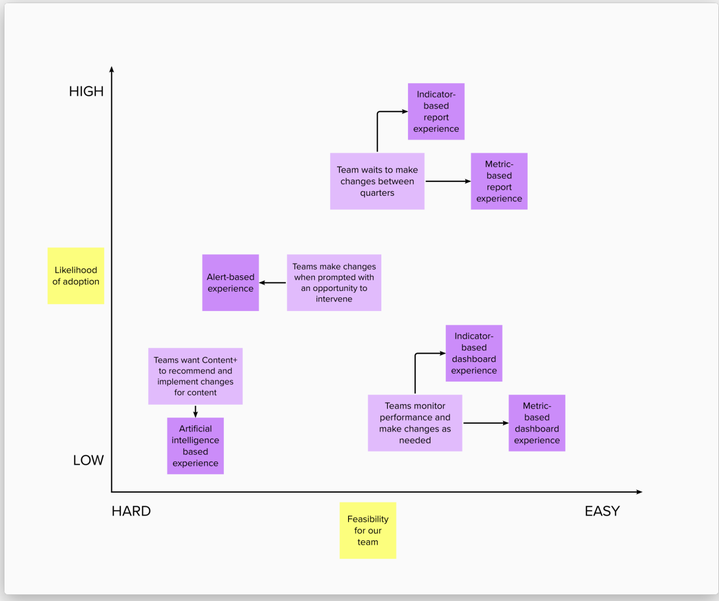
I decided on an experience that would be an evolution of the Quarter in Review. I knew from research that teams updated offerings quarterly between sales cycles and our team had evidence that offering teams resonated with the report.



A

A Mural activity for feedback

I shared the three core users, the jobs they performed, and the metrics I hoped to support them with. Then I facilitated feedback.

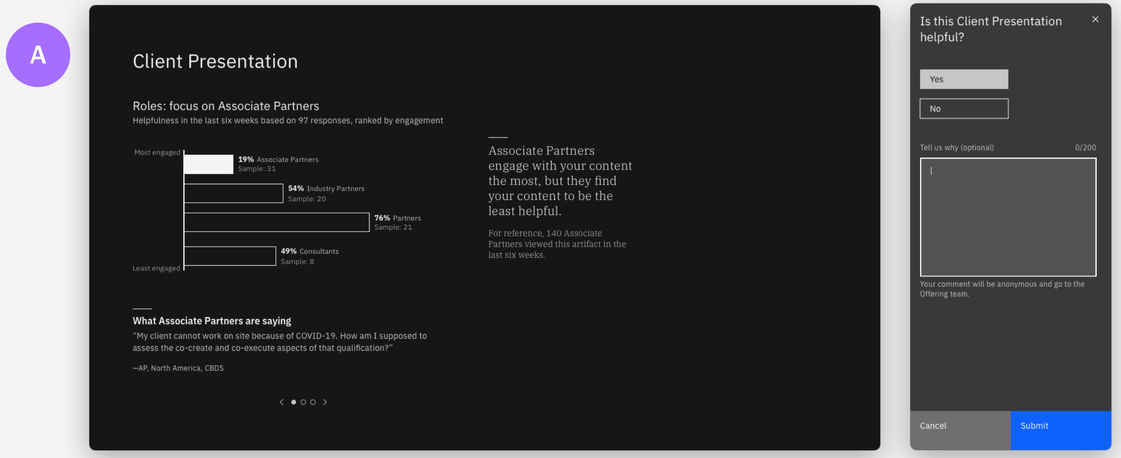


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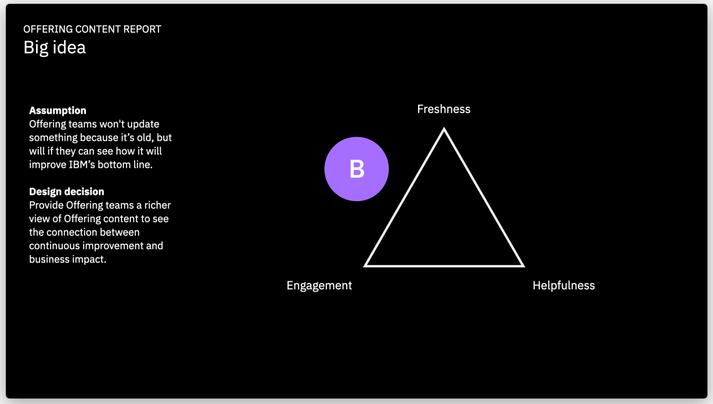
I explored how qualitative scoring and combining indicators could motivate users
After moving through an iterative design process, I presented the Offering Content Report to my stakeholders in design. I brought forward challenging ideas that targeted motivating offering teams to maintain their offering content.

The first was introducing written feedback by consultants and a metric called Helpfulness. The metric "quantified the qualitative." I prioritized it first because I hypothesized knowing sentiment first would motivate users to then search through comments to uncover why (A).

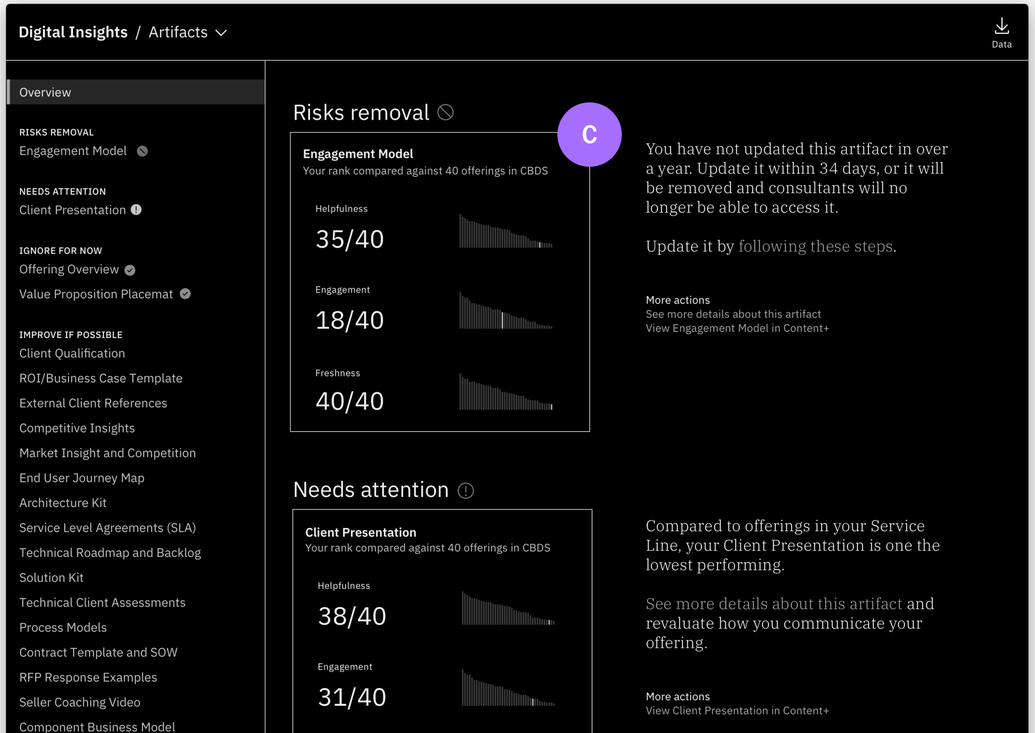
Second, I introduced indicators called Freshness, Engagement, and Helpfulness and showed them in context with each other (B).



Quantifying the qualitative
The helpfulness score came from a one question survey presented to consultants in Content+.



An iron triangle
This is a slide explains my rationale for showing helpfulness, engagement, and freshness in context with each other (C).



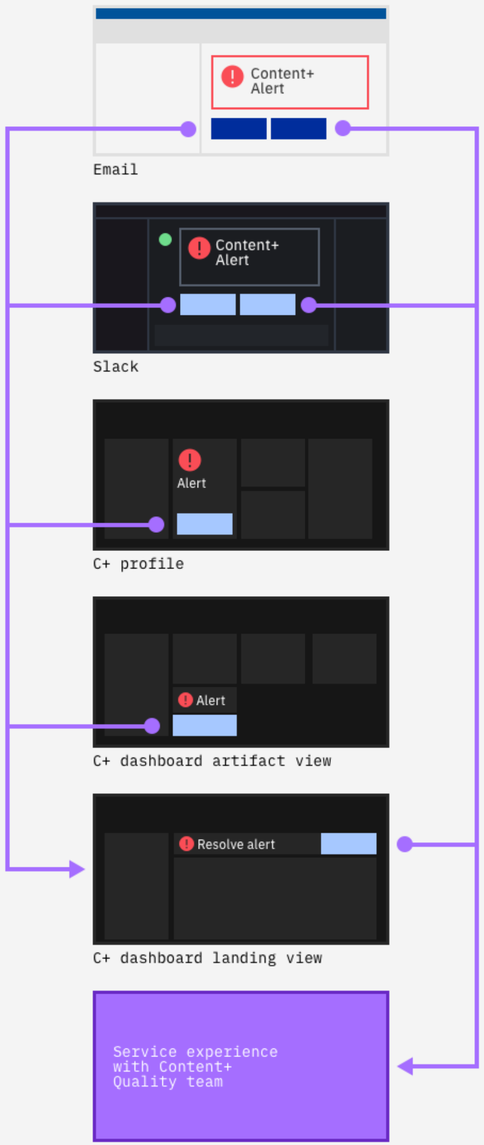
I pivoted toward a dashboard focused on compliance embedded into Content+
While the report had merit, stakeholder expectations evolved and technical hurdles were diminishing. I greeted these conditions as an opportunity to recast my vision to help offering teams provide quality content for consultants.

I pivoted toward an alert-based dashboard integrated into the Content+ experience that focused on compliance.

The new experience would help our stakeholders achieve their objectives by giving them more power to govern content on the platform. For offering teams, the dashboard integrated into Content+ meant one less location and interface to adopt.

To demonstrate these changes, I used user vignettes that illustrated three scenarios. One of which was a vignette demonstrating compliance (A).

A



Step 1: Notify
Sam, an offering team member, sees an alert from the Content+ quality team that tells her an artifact is out of compliance.

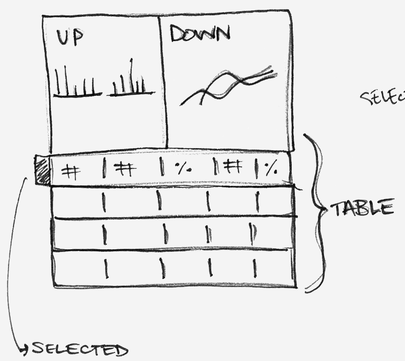
Step 2: Explore
Sam sees a countdown to when Content+ will remove her offering's artifact if not updated.

Step 3: Resolve
The dashboard pushes her into a service experience where she is guided to get back into compliance.

I changed the dashboard's density by introducing tabs

Pivoting to a dashboard and a growing list of metrics reshaped how I thought about the density of data. It was something I identified while making the report, but hadn't yet resolved.

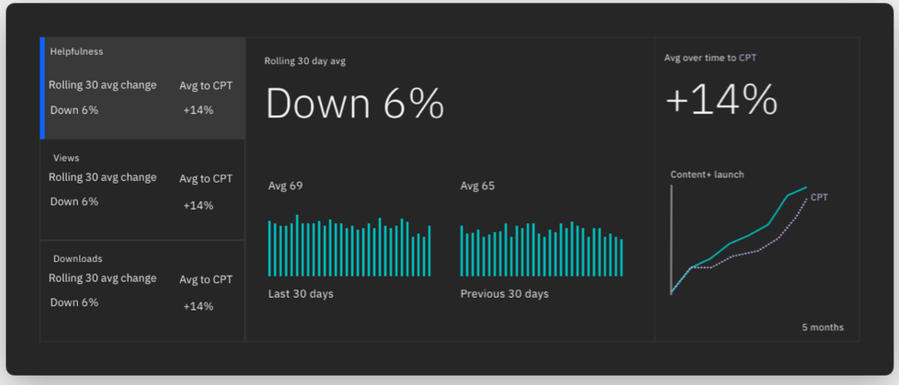
Without a change, the dashboard would be long and monotone (A). Resultantly, it would become hard to navigate and follow. To overcome this, I introduced tabbing in headers and data tables (B).

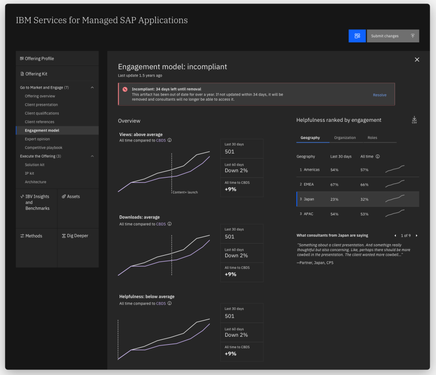


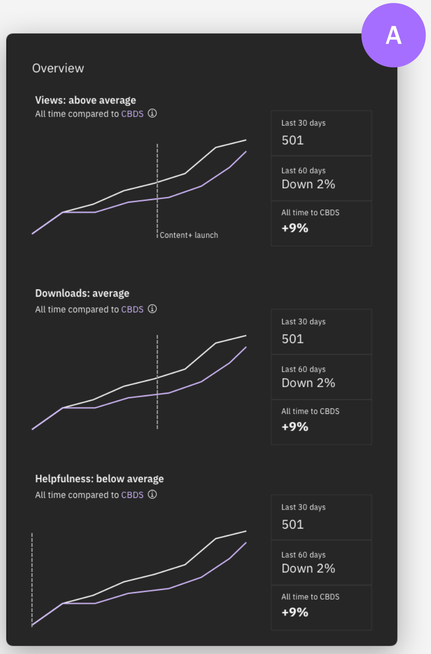


Sketching to high-fidelity

I started with sketches and brought these directly into a high-fidelity concepts.

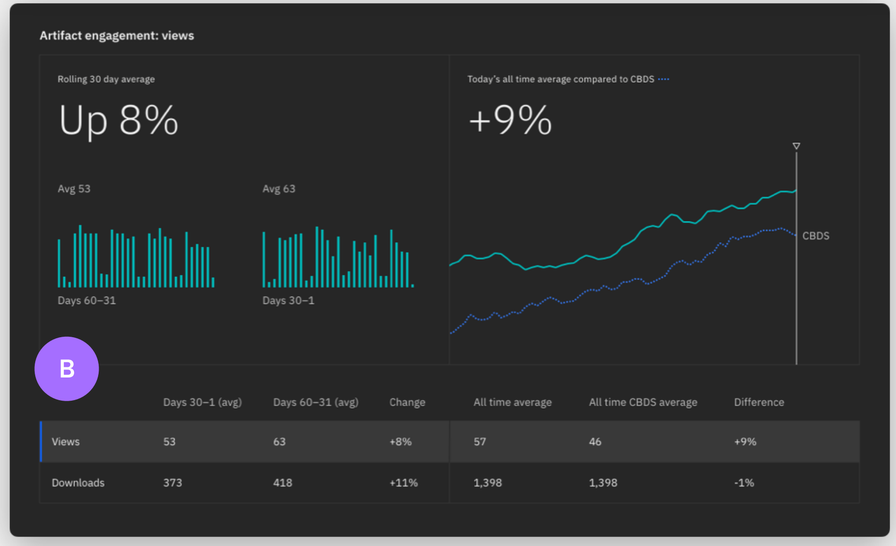






Finding efficient use of space

I landed here because this layout gave visualizations more room and allowed the bottom section to double as a data table.

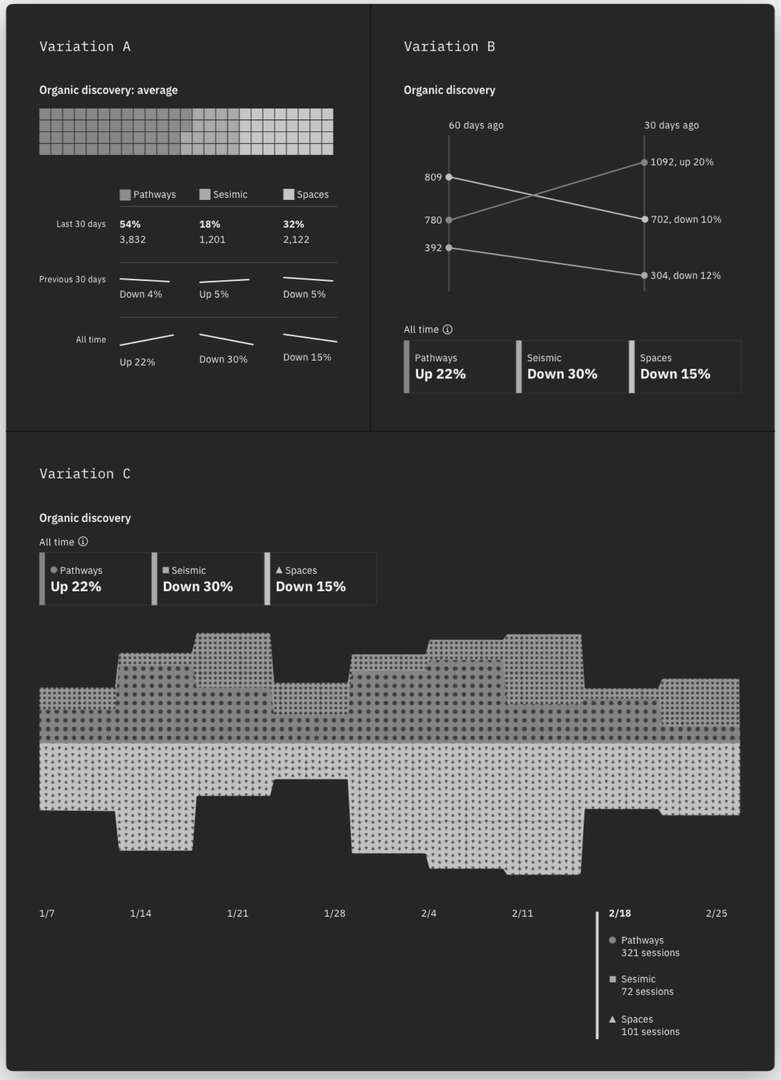


I iterated to make engaging charts and made them accessible with best practices

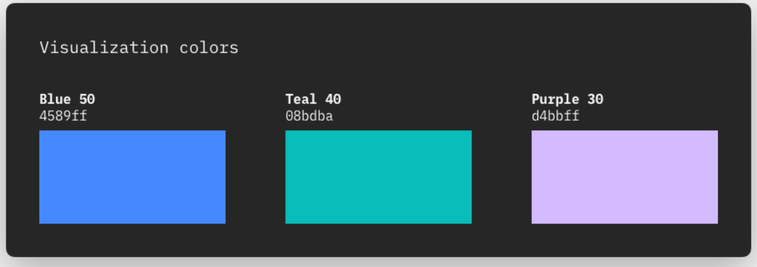
The final version of the dashboard focused on simple stories about offering content: typically single metrics over time.

Line charts were appropriate to convey information, but if the report relied too heavily on them they would hold less attention and weaken navigation. So I put effort into breaking this up by exploring appropriate but visually distinct visualizations where appropriate (A).

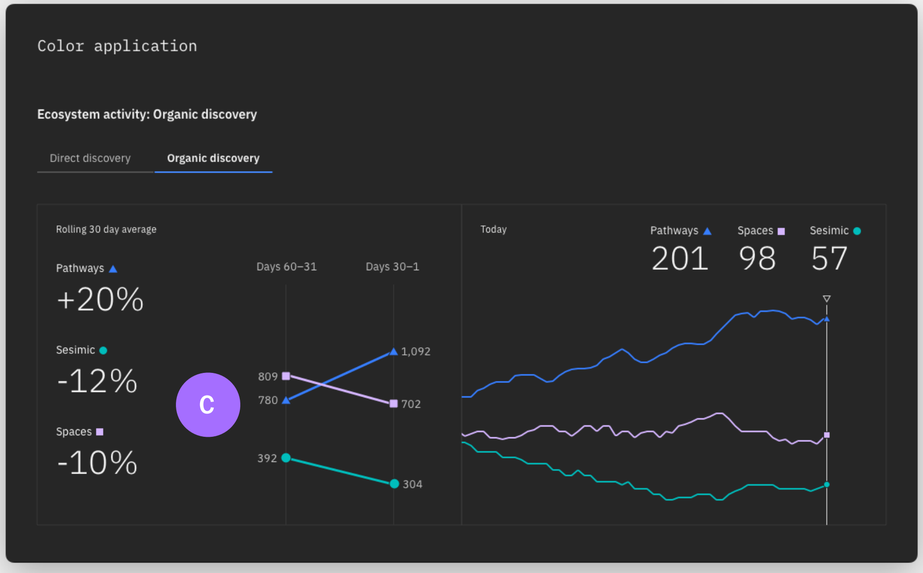
As I branched into new concepts, accessibility became a concern of mine. For color, I used Carbon's guidelines for data visualization color palettes as a resource. These colors passed the 3:1 contrast ratio for UI elements and also controlled for color blindness (B). I also used shape to indicate different categories (C).



A



B



C

I delivered a vision for the dashboard and a plan to capture the data to support it

The reporting experience I designed articulated a solution aimed at ensuring higher quality content for consultants.

I targeted building trust between offering content and the content audiences by developing a vision for how Content+ would express its governance model. The alert-based experience respectfully nudged teams to resolve outdated content to ensure fresh content for consultants.

I also championed a way for offering teams to receive qualitative feedback for the first time ever. Offering teams work in a complex organization and outside their small circle of influence, they have little to no understanding how useful their content truly is.

In addition to the reporting experience, I delivered a qualitative feedback loop mechanism ready for code that supplied data for the reporting experience. This provided the ability to finally show offering teams a view of the organization’s sentiment.

Led generative research that surfaced who on offering teams updated content and why, shaping the dashboard's design decisions.

Designed an alert-based dashboard within Content+ to nudge offering teams to resolve outdated content and strengthen governance.

Designed a feedback system that enabled offering teams to gather and visualize feedback from sellers across the company

The lesson learned: stories are just as important for designers as they are for non-designers

Content+'s team structure was complex and the platform's users were familiar

Two conditions influenced how I designed and communicated in this project.

First, Content+'s team structure was complex and political. For that reason, my design leadership placed limits on how I engaged and presented to non-design stakeholders.

Secondly our design team, including design leadership, had a shared understanding of our users. They had been at the center of numerous projects over several years.

With only design stakeholders, I presented my work in a critique format

Designing without non-design stakeholders was unfamiliar in my design career and I chose to present my work more like a critique rather than a formal playback.

In critiques, the audience is almost always design peers. The emphasis is largely on the design decisions made in the interface and the paths the user takes through it. In a formal playback, the audience is technology and business stakeholders.

Design decisions about the interface are still there but designers use storytelling to emphasize the outcomes the experience produces for the user and the business.

Storytelling would have better elicited feedback about evolving expectations

Treating presentations like critiques set me back. After an important review of the reporting experience, it was clear my design was out of alignment. Ultimately I adjusted and filled in the missing gap.

In retrospect, repeating the user and business outcomes through a story would have helped my design leader to consume the reporting experience. Stakeholder expectations were evolving and storytelling techniques would have worked their magic to catch changes.

In hard settings, storytelling and creative communication closes feedback loops

Efficiently capturing feedback matters when conditions are less than ideal. Content+ was a highly ambitious project sailing its course through the height of the COVID-19 pandemic. On several occasions my design leadership was unavailable and missed scheduled touch points to review my work.

As these conditions more or less continued on future projects, I used the lessons learned on Content+ and made successful adjustments. First, storytelling never falls to the wayside. Second, recording playbacks for offline review and other creative ways of alignment have become standard techniques I use.